STANDARD FORM NO. 64

Office Memorandum • UNITED STATES GOVERNMENT

TO :
Via :
FROM :

DATE: 16 November 1951

SUBJECT: "Side Tone Delay"

1. Since [redacted], Chief of the [redacted] was instrumental in setting up the demonstration for the "side tone delay" instrument and since he has been in continuous consultation with the writer and his associates in this matter, the writer took the liberty of showing [redacted] the attached memorandum and related papers.

2. [redacted] informed the writer that he agrees with the general thought in the attached memorandum concerning the instrument.

[redacted]

A/B, I, 42, 8

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SUBJECT: "Side Tone Delay"

1. Reference is made to the attached memorandum from , OSI, and other related papers.

2. For a matter of record, the "side tone delay" is an instrument, or series of instruments, which is designed to confuse and confound an individual under interrogation. The principle of the device simply stated is that an individual's speech is confused when sound uttered by the individual is carried to the individual's ears a fraction of a second or longer after he has uttered the sound. This confusion, it is believed, will cause an individual who is lying or evading an answer to have the feeling that his confused speech is due to guilt. Hence forcing him to admit guilt or becoming so confused as to make obvious the fact that he is evasive or lying.

3. The instrument proper, which is being used for demonstration at the present time, consists of a tape recording unit and a receiving unit which, in a rough sense, are portable. However, the laboratory instruments have not yet been perfected and are cumbersome and non-portable.

4. Concerning I & SO interests in this matter, it is believed that we would have two possible interests. The first would be in connection with the Polygraph Section of I & SO and the second in connection with the "Artichoke" work.

5. In so far as the Polygraph Section is concerned, it is felt that if the instrument could be perfected, it might possibly be of use on individual cases where the polygraph clearly indicated deception, lying, or evasion, and where extremely important and questionable matters are involved. The writer doubts that the instrument could be used effectively on the normal or routine polygraph case and feels that it would have to be reserved for special work or cases that are not capable of being completely resolved by the polygraph technique. However, it is believed that if the instrument could be technically perfected, it would probably have value to the Polygraph Section.

6. The use of the instrument by "Artichoke" depends a great deal upon its technical development. "Artichoke" contemplates a far more subtle technique for obtaining positive information and, in addition, contemplates obtaining information from unwilling individuals or individuals who refuse to co-operate in any way. At the present stage, it would appear that the instrument could only be used on a "volunteer basis".

7. Since the instrument is to be developed as an Agency project and not as an I & SO specific function, it is the opinion of the writer and his associates that the project is probably worthwhile and should be supported. There are, however, from our point of view, a number of items which should be considered in the development of the project. These are set forth immediately following:

1. If the instrument is perfected and has been demonstrated to be effective, a portable instrument, if it could be developed, would be of great advantage. This would be valuable for Agency personnel overseas or for special work requiring teams to go into the field.

2. If at all possible electronically, it would be of great advantage if, by the use of a directional microphone and directional loud speakers, the earphones could be eliminated and no attachments required for placing on the subject.

3. Experiments should be run as to whether or not the device could be linked directly into a polygraph. However, these experiments should be very cautiously worked out so as not to give artificial or overstrong responses due to the confusion resulting from the "side tone delay".

C 4. If tests are to be run by _____ and his Associates on the device, they should not be confined to criminal investigations alone nor should they be confined to purely personnel matters. The instrument should be checked against all types of questions, particularly identity questions and questions involving a person's loyalty, etc., etc.

5. Specific efforts should be made to see that the instrument does not produce indications of guilt in individuals who are innocent, but who become confused by the operation of the machine.

B C 6. Although the project was brought to our attention and fully co-ordinated with the _____, it is felt that this Agency, if it is paying for the development of the instrument, should have at all times, access to the testing and authority to consult with and advise _____ and his Associates. Furthermore, if experimentation shows that the instrument has a decided advantage and is testing successfully, this Agency, and particularly I & SO, should be authorized to send men to the project to be trained in the use of the instrument as soon as possible.

7. While the instrument is being tested, tests should be conducted in foreign languages if possible and tests should also be run involving the use of an interpretator. This may be necessary in some future work of this Agency.

8. The writer and his associates and [redacted], Chief of the Polygraph Section, have discussed this matter at some length. All are agreed that the device may have merit and, if effectively developed, may be a definite aid to advanced interrogation. Its use as a routine instrument is doubted. Since [redacted] and his Associates appear to have started work in this field, it is believed they are best suited to carry on this work although, undoubtedly, [redacted] will directly profit from the development of the instrument in his commercial polygraph work.

9. The writer is unable to state whether or not $35,000 is excessive for this type of a project but on the basis of the budget submitted, the costs do not appear too heavy.

[redacted]